of bullets from jezail marksmen hidden high in the gullies above them. ‘I was riding a few paces in advance of the corps,’ he wrote,

> the balls striking rather close. I turned around and said to an officer, ‘Those fellows do not fire badly.’ And true enough, for the moment afterwards I was struck. The ball hit me so hard that my friend answered, ‘You are hit, old fellow,’ but I needed not to be told to make me aware of it. The regiment galloped on to get from under the fire. I was obliged to dismount, or rather half fell from my horse, and dragged and supported by my groom and a sepoy, I lay down behind a piece of rock which sheltered me from the fire, until after some time a dhoolie was brought for me and I was carried into camp at Jamrud.[118]

Chamberlain had been hit with the very last shots of the war. Jamrud marked an invisible boundary, after which the murderous violence of Afghanistan abruptly stopped. By evening, the Rev. I. N. Allen had reached the very different world of the outskirts of Peshawar. ‘Men were sitting by the roadside selling grain and sweetmeats,’ he wrote in amazement. ‘These were strange sights to us who had for months been without seeing a human being, except as an enemy.’[119]

There followed a long five-week march through the Punjab to the boundary of the Company territories on the Sutlej, near Ferozepur. Chamberlain was carried the whole way in a litter, ‘too ill to be amused or see the country . . . Hundreds of men died during our march from fatigue or wounds. Comparatively speaking I was one of the lucky ones. But I hope I shall never again go through what I then suffered.’[120]

The first troops reached Ferozepur just before Christmas, on 23 December. As they marched over the bridge of boats spanning the river, Lord Ellenborough was waiting in person to greet the troops, with a regimental band playing ‘See the Conquering Hero Comes’. As Colin Mackenzie’s sister-in-law, Julia Margaret Cameron, the pioneering photographer, memorably described him, Ellenborough was ‘flighty and unmanageable in all matters of business . . . [but] violently enthusiastic on all military matters, and they alone seem to occupy his interests or his attention’.

A great ceremonial arch of bamboo, coloured cotton and bunting had been erected, ‘so closely resembling a gigantic gallows’, wrote Mackenzie, ‘that the soldiers marched under it with peals of laughter’.[121] Beyond stretched a row two miles long of 250 caparisoned elephants, whose trunks the Governor General had personally helped paint.[122] He had also organised a cavalcade of celebrations and parades to mark what he termed the